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It was for Patna as the monsoon of 1574 set in, that Akbar set sail.

The rain-swollen waters of the Yamuna were filled with ‘wonderfully fashioned boats’.[24] Each had an animal-shaped prow, some had gardens on board, others carried the emperor’s ‘equipments and establishments’,[25] from armour and drums to carpets and kitchenware – even two favourite elephants, Balsundar and Suman, each with his own suite and two she-elephants for company.

Akbar’s ship, writes Badauni, had a prow shaped like a crocodile, and it was with the fearsome ease of that amphibious beast that the emperor navigated his way to Patna – disembarking to hunt every day, ‘searching into science and poetry’ every night, riding the river’s high waters as if they were just another musth elephant.[26] The same could not be said of his retinue.

While the bulk of Akbar’s army marched alongside, on the riverbank, many of his courtiers, servants and nobility were travelling by boat, too; and they were terrified. The monsoon is no time to sail.

All the ‘tumult of the waves’, writes Abul Fazl, of the day on which Akbar set sail, all ‘the force of the wind, the rush of the . . . rain, the roar of the thunder, and the flashing of . . . lightning produced a strange appearance’. The storms did not subside; indeed, they got worse, and ships sank regularly. On one particularly bad day, eleven boats sank into the river, like so many pebbles flung to their fate. Another time, a sinking ship took two imperial cheetahs with it. There was a day when the storm was so strong that many men disembarked in alarm, preferring to walk rather than follow those unfortunate animals. Akbar, of course, ‘went on by boat with . . . cheerful heart’. What was a little rain? When they crossed from the Yamuna into the Ganga, he led 500 of his elephants into its raging waters.

Only one drowned.

A lost animal here, a handful of broken ships there, these were no hurdles. Akbar looked, as the ambitious must, on the bright side. Wading into the Ganga with his elephants, Akbar watched a ‘large fish’ emerge from the river. Was it a Gangetic dolphin? Perhaps; more importantly, for Akbar it was a good omen. Another day, out on his daily hunt, he made one of his auguries by cheetah – this time, however, the deer escaped the first